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First and second-level agenda-setting in the 2014 Indian general election: a time-series analysis of party-media relation

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ABSTRACT
The role of the press as a political watchdog is crucial to the functioning of democracy. Especially in the run-up to elections, voters depend on the media's presentation of parties and candidates to make informed, responsible choices at the ballot box. But who, then, influences the news media? Empirical evidence in the United States and Europe suggests that political party campaigns and election coverage in the news media are interconnected and influence each other. This study tests whether such agenda-setting effects between party campaigns and the media also take place in the general elections in the world's largest democracy, India. India's western-type political system has a distinct media system characterized by high competition, diversification, non-consolidation and formal and informal ties between the media, commercial interests and political actors. Content analysis and Granger's causality test of newspaper coverage ($N = 716$) and party campaign messages ($N = 458$) found that agenda-setting effects do occur in India, but are largely bi-directional. We also found an overwhelming focus of both newspapers' election coverage and of all major party campaigns on one single candidate, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)'s Narendra Modi. This, we argue, is a result of the broader trends that have shaped Indian politics in recent years. The significant correlations and non-significant causal effects between party campaign and media coverage also indicate a trade-off situation between political power negotiation and political balance in the press.

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Introduction

Media function as the particularly important source from which people obtain political information. The salience of candidates in the media directly affects the perceived importance of these candidates among the public (McCombs, 2014; McCombs & Shaw, 1972). As the media exert such an influential role on awareness and even opinion formation, the question of who influences the media becomes central, especially during the election time period (Baumann, 2016; Zhou, Kim, & Kim, 2013).

The flow of arguments from party campaigns to the press in the context of elections has mainly been studied in the United States and in Europe (McCombs, 2014). In India – the

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world's largest democracy playing an increasingly confident and aspiring role on the international stage – these effects have to our knowledge never been examined systematically. Nonetheless, a look at the political coverage of the Indian press and the campaign strategies of the major parties leads to the assumption that the flow of arguments between political actors and the media are extensive. The absence of agenda-setting studies in India is surprising, as the country is the world's largest national media market and home to 10 of the world's 20 largest daily newspapers (International Federation of Audit Bureaux of Circulations, 2011). Because of this neglect of the Indian case from previous agenda-setting research, this exploratory study is based on an entirely new data set (Baumann, 2016).

The 2014 elections of the lower house of the Indian parliament, the Lok Sabha, served as an ideal case to fill this research gap. Beyond identifying agenda-setting effects in India, this study aims to contribute to a better understanding and assessment of the independence of the Indian press. In India, where increasing literacy rates and fast-growing newspaper sales go hand in hand with demands of an ever-expanding middle class for more political participation, the independence of the press serves as an indicator of the quality and maturity of democracy. If the parties are able to exert influence on the portrayal of their candidates in the country's most influential national newspapers, then press independence from political parties may be poor. If, on the other hand, newspapers portray the main candidates' independent of the parties' campaigns, then they can be seen as resistant to political influence.

The agenda-setting theory serves as the theoretical framework for this study. The core proposition of the theory is the transfer of salience from one agenda to another agenda. The salience of objects – issues, candidates, public figures, organizations – is the first level of agenda-setting, and the salience of the attributes of those objects is the second level of agenda-setting. Second-level research, in particular, underscores the need for a more systematic perusal of the attitudinal outcomes of agenda-setting. An object, defined similar to that of an attitude object in psychology, is the element to which attributes refer, such as issues, political candidates, and so on (Lopez-Escobar, Llamas, & McCombs, 1998). Since the early 1980s, agenda-setting theory considers how candidate images – their attributes – are constructed. Most of the agenda-setting studies to this day have prioritized the effects of media coverage on public opinion (e.g. King, 1997; McCombs, Llamas, Lopez-Escobar, & Rey, 1997; Weaver, Graber, McCombs, & Eyal, 1981). Since the 1990s, studies have expanded the original agenda to include multiple objects and their attributes in the news. Existing studies in the U.S. context have found strong to moderate agenda-setting effects from party to media (e.g. Lopez-Escobar et al., 1998), but longitudinal studies also found party-media relationships changed across time (Becketti, 2011). Studies in Asian contexts in general confirmed some degree of agenda-setting effects between the media, political parties and the public, but the direction and strength of the effects varied (Baumann, 2016; Luo, 2011; Wang, 2016; Zheng, 2017).

This study focused on the election campaigns of India's two main national parties and a rapidly expanding third party in the 2014 general elections to identify the salience of their major candidates in each party's campaign as well as in newspaper election campaign coverage. Two newspapers, the largest circulated English language newspaper, the *Times of India,* and one of the most influential Hindi language newspapers, *Hindustan,* were selected for a content analysis. The content analysis also examined the portrayal of each

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party's own leading candidate as well as the depiction of the respective adversaries (the candidates of the two opponent parties). Finally, Granger's causality test was applied to test for possible causal flows between party campaigns and newspapers coverage.

Literature review

Agenda-setting in political campaigns

The ability of the mass media to set the public agenda has been a major focus of empirical mass communication research since the late 1960s. With their Chapel Hill study, McCombs and Shaw (1972) demonstrated how the mass media were able to influence the public agenda during the 1968 U.S. presidential election campaign. Since this seminal inquiry of the correlation between the mass media agenda and the public agenda, agenda-setting research has produced over 450 peer-reviewed articles published by academic journals in English until 2012 (Zhou et al., 2013). Over the years, agenda-setting theory has expanded from a first level of agenda-setting (McCombs & Shaw, 1972; Roberts, Wanta, & Dzwo, 2002), the concern with the salience of objects (such as candidates) to a second level: attribute agenda-setting. The second level is concerned with the transfer of the salience of objects' attributes, both *substantive attributes* (such as characters of candidates) and *affective attributes* (the tones media use when they describe candidates) (Lopez-Escobar et al., 1998; McCombs, Shaw, & Weaver, 2004; Takeshita, 1997, 2007). Because of the broad empirical evidence of the media's ability to influence the public's agenda, the question of how media content evolves becomes essential.

Many forces shape the media agenda, such as journalistic norms and routines, organizational culture and fiscal constraints on the media side (Entman, 1993; Reese, Gandy, & Grant, 2001; Shoemaker, Eichholz, Kim, & Wrigley, 2001), as well as lobbying, public relations and advertising on the political actors' side (Brandenburg, 2002; Walgrave & De Swert, 2007). In the context of elections, agenda-setting at the second level places special emphasis on candidate images. Prior research suggests that some of the more prominent attributes highlighted by both the media and voters include candidate qualifications and personality traits (Graber, 1972; Nimmo & Savage, 1976). McCombs, Lopez-Escobar, and Llamas (2000) found close correlation between the valence of newspapers' candidate portrayal (positive, neutral, and negative candidate attributes) in five substantive candidate attributes (ideology/issue positions, biographical details, perceived qualifications, integrity, and personality and image) and the valence of audience descriptions concerning those same candidates during the 1996 Spanish general election. Coleman and Banning (2006) found that television news images of candidates exhibiting positive or negative behavior such as gestures and facial expressions convey impressions that are perceived as sympathetic or unsympathetic by the audience. Other studies have found attribute agenda-setting effects for news coverage of political candidates on the public's image of those candidates (Becker & McCombs, 1978; Kim & McCombs, 2007; King, 1997; Weaver et al., 1981).

When it comes to the relationship between the mass media and political parties, the media's political agenda-setting power is contingent upon a number of conditions, including both media and political context variables (Walgrave & Van Aelst, 2006). In

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terms of media variables, researchers have discovered that newspapers, and especially national newspapers of high status (with extensive and in-depth political coverage), are more likely to affect parties and policy makers (Roberts & McCombs, 1994). High congruence between the coverage of different media outlets and media types results in stronger impact on the political agenda (Eilders, 1997, 2000, 2001). Moreover, 'focusing events' (Cobb & Elder, 1971) such as crises and symbolic political agendas such as candidates' images and strategies are favored by the media in their political coverage (Wood & Peake, 1998). As a result, party campaigns often explicitly target and respond to the media logic in order to achieve the desired coverage (Pritchard & Berkowitz, 1993). In addition, political news in different time-periods leads to different party-media agenda-setting dynamics. Norris, Curtice, Sanders, Scammell, and Semetko (1999) found that the media failed to set the parties' agenda and vice versa during election time. Similarly, Dalton, Beck, Huckfeldt, and Koetzle (1998) found that both the media and the candidates were on the same track in the 1992 U.S. presidential campaign, yet little evidence was found for causality. For these scholars, reasons for limited agenda-setting effects during campaigns are two-fold. On the one hand, parties and candidates are vigorously trying to bypass the media and directly target the public with ads and flyers (Semetko, 1996). On the other hand, the modern media tend to follow their own media logic rather than simply adopting political agenda inputs (Brants & Van Praag, 2000) and produce balanced news rather than favoring specific parties (Semetko, 1996).

In terms of political variables, political configuration is an important factor (Walgrave & Van Aelst, 2006). While the incumbent party stresses the positive aspects of its government and candidates, the opposition's campaign strategy is often characterized by the opposite logic. Accordingly, although incumbent parties are more newsworthy during non-election times, they attract less attention in times of election campaigns (van Aelst & De Swert, 2009). When there are more than two parties campaigning for an election, party-media agenda-setting effects are largely affected by the competitions among parties (Hopmann, Elmelund-Præstekær, Vliegenthart, de Vreese, & Albæk, 2010). For example, when some parties are either more relevant in the political system or supportive of alternative policies, they tend to receive more attention from both the media and other opposition parties (Sartori, 2005). Parties which communicate more dramatic stories also tend to get more media attention (Hopmann et al., 2010). In addition, political balance plays a significant role in the media-party relationship during elections. If party A extensively focuses on one issue in its campaign, the media are likely to turn to parties' B and C with regard to the same issue in order to achieve balanced coverage (Walgrave & Van Aelst, 2006).

Politics and the media in India

The democratic foundation of India's political, judicial and media systems is rooted in colonial times. After independence from Britain in 1947, India was characterized by extreme poverty and inequality (Khilnani, 1999; Kulke & Rothermund, 2010; Oldenburg, 2010). However, India has succeeded in establishing a democratic system and has gradually strengthened its democratic foundations. From British rule, the country inherited much of the colonial state, including the judicial and the bureaucratic system as well as

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its constitutional structure, and a press which has operated freely at all times, with the exception of the period from 1975 to 1977, when Prime Minister Indira Gandhi declared a state of emergency to counter anti-government agitations (Oldenburg, 2010).

In the twenty-first century, political pressure on the media in India has become more salient. Political influence on the media is often not straightforward, but is exercised in opaque and subtle ways. Before the 2009 general elections, the 'paid news scam' became public (Thakurta & Reddy, 2010). Some newspapers had published political PR-content in their editorials without declaring the origins of these 'paid news'. Journalists in India are not sufficiently protected from prosecution and harassment in the courts. According to Oldenburg,

> courts can require the appearance of editors to answer charges of defamation filed by ordinary citizens or for 'hurting the sensibilities of a particular community', which is practiced to force journalists to hire lawyers, appear before the courts and get adverse publicity (Oldenburg, 2010, pp. 83–87).

Oldenburg further argues that only the largest and most economically successful newspapers can hold out against those inducements.

But for all these shortfalls, the press also aims to function as the fourth estate in India,

> […] serving to hold government to account on occasion, to the extent of forcing major leaders to resign. It has certainly been able to provide the forum for competing parties and candidates to disseminate their views, and has also represented an important platform for organizations and individuals of civil society to present alternative positions and analyses (Oldenburg, 2010, p. 84).

The Indian media system and the status of the press

This study analyzed the role of the press in the 2014 election campaign because of its role in the Indian media landscape. In India, the press in 2014 still enjoyed a privileged status compared to the electronic media. Contrary to developments in the West where the Internet has led to drastic concentration processes among the traditional media and where the sale of print newspapers has sharply decreased (Hooke, 2012; The Economist, 2011), only about 7% of Indians used the internet regularly in 2010. According to Hooke (2012), 'India is considered among those developing countries that will last see the wrath of digital penetration because Internet penetration is still very low and consumer migration [to online] has not yet happened' (p. 58). Television is also not a threat to newspapers' dominant position in the Indian media landscape, given that about 70% of households have limited access to satellite TV, but they can afford newspapers because of their low costs (0.015–0.06 USD).

Accordingly, newspaper readership figures in India are rapidly growing (Indian Readership Survey, 2012). India is the world's largest and fastest growing newspaper market with more than 110 million copies circulated daily (International Federation of Audit Bureaux of Circulations, 2011), accounting for more than 20% of all dailies across the world. Not least because of improving literacy rates, the Indian press plays an important role in the formation of public opinion (Datta, 2006). Elite newspapers such as *The New York Times* tend to set the media agenda for other newspapers and television news channels. Therefore, those newspapers are inter-media agenda-setters (McCombs, 2014; Roberts & McCombs, 1994). Accordingly, parties and the candidates that get more

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extensive and more favorable coverage in these papers of high status are more likely to gain an advantage over their adversaries. Since colonial times, the English language press has been regarded as politically more relevant than the vernacular press in India. However, 'the rise of vernacular political elites spearheading plebeian politics proved instrumental in the increasing role of the vernacular media in regional and national politics.' (Neyazi, 2014, p. 183). Therefore, the English language *Times of India* and the Hindi language *Hindustan* are among the most influential newspapers in their respective language. They are also among the most widely circulated and most widely read national newspapers that cover national politics extensively.

Agenda-setting research in western contexts has produced extensive evidence of correlation between political campaigns and media coverage, yet the study of the causal direction of agenda-setting effects has yielded mixed results (Kiousis, Kim, McDevitt, & Ostrowski, 2009; Kiousis, Mitrook, Wu, & Seltzer, 2006; Lopez-Escobar et al., 1998; Roberts & McCombs, 1994; Weaver & Elliott, 1985). The geographical distribution of agenda-setting research in general is heavily unbalanced. Although scholars in the last decade started analysing agenda-setting effects in non-western countries (King, 1997; Song, 2007; Takeshita, 2007), a distinct 'western-centrism' in agenda-setting research is obvious with only relatively few studies dedicated to non-western settings, including Japan, Taiwan and South Korea, which are the three most developed Asian democracies (McCombs et al., 2004). Less developed countries are severely under-studied. This is surprising, as agenda-setting effects at least implicitly allow for a deeper and more nuanced understanding of core democratic processes such as public opinion formation and the relationship between politics and the media. It is especially surprising that the vivid and fast-growing media landscape of India has been entirely excluded from this body of research. India, one of the largest and most influential emerging powers with its enormous newspaper market and its unique cultural and media system setup, serves as an ideal case to expand the geographical scope of agenda-setting research and thus to improve the theory's global range of validity (Baumann, 2016). Accordingly, we raised the following research questions and hypotheses:

RQ1: What are the party campaign and newspaper coverage patterns in terms of (a) candidate salience, (b) substantive candidate attributes and (c) affective candidate attributes in the 2014 general elections in India?

H1: The salience of candidates in the party campaigns significantly correlates with the salience of candidates in the newspapers.

H2: The salience of *substantive* candidate attributes presented in the party campaigns significantly correlates with the salience of substantive candidate attributes presented in the newspapers.

H3: The salience of *affective* candidate attributes presented in the party campaigns significantly correlates with the salience of affective candidate attributes presented in the newspapers.

RQ2: What is the causal relationship between parties and newspapers' agendas in terms of (a) candidate salience, (b) substantive candidate attributes and (c) affective candidate attributes in the 2014 general election in India?

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Method

Data collection

The 2014 general elections in India presented an opportunity to test these hypothesized agenda-setting effects. The elections to the lower house of parliament took place between 7th of April and 12th of May 2014. As the goal of the study was to test the agenda-setting effects between party campaigns and newspaper coverage of the major parties' leading candidates, we conducted two content analyses, one of the newspapers' campaign coverage and one of each party's campaign.

Newspaper agenda

To establish the newspapers' candidate and candidate attribute agendas, we analyzed the last six weeks of campaign coverage prior to the last election-day in *The Times of India*, and in *Hindustan*.[1]

The reason we chose national newspapers is three-folds: First, this study focused on national politics, therefore newspapers with a nationwide outlook are a more appropriate sample than regional newspapers. In the context of India, although the media market is more diverse compared to the West (Shahin, Zheng, Sturm, & Fadnis, 2016), national newspapers exert substantial influence on the regional press. National newspapers, therefore, play an agenda-setting role for other media outlets (Haque & Narag, 1983; McCombs, 2014). Among all the languages spoken in India, the largest numbers of newspapers are published in Hindi. At the same time, India is the biggest market for English language publications outside Britain and the U.S. (Sarkar, 1994). Second, among the national newspapers, the *Times of India* and *Hindustan* are among the country's most influential daily newspapers in their respective language that cover national politics elaborately. Both publications are among the world's newspapers with the largest readership (Indian Readership Survey, 2014). Third, we chose these two newspapers for our study of media-party relations, because their historical roots lie in opposite political circles. The *Times of India* was founded by the British during the colonial period, opposing the Congress independence movement, while *Hindustan* was a publication of the Congress independence movement. In order to investigate whether the two newspapers' historical ties (*Hindustan*) and opposition (*Times of India*) with regard to the ruling Congress Party were still prevalent in the course of the 2014 general elections, we selected these two newspapers for the analysis.

In the six weeks of campaign coverage we analyzed all 42 issues of the *Times of India* and all 42 issues of *Hindustan*.

Party campaign agenda

We conducted content analyses of India's two major national parties', the *Indian National Congress* party (INC), the opposition Indian People's Party (*Bharatiya Janata Party*, BJP), and a smaller but rapidly expanding third party, the anti-corruption and anti-establishment Common Man's Party (*Aam Aadmi Party*, AAP). This allowed to identify the parties' candidate agendas. We focused on the designated Prime Minister candidates of these three parties, as they were by far the most prominent candidates in the 2014

general elections. No other candidates had realistic chances of becoming Prime Minister. The BJP had nominated Narendra Modi, the Chief Minister of the state of Gujarat, as its leading candidate. Essentially, the BJP campaign was entirely focused on the person of Modi. In the Congress Party (INC), the youngest offspring of the Nehru-Gandhi dynasty, Rahul Gandhi, was designated as the future party leader. Representing the fifth generation of the Nehru-Gandhi family, Rahul Gandhi was not officially nominated as the Prime Minister candidate. However, Rahul's mother and president of the Congress party's, Sonia Gandhi, had gradually pushed Rahul to take up more leadership responsibility in the party. Thus, the Congress campaign was centered around Rahul Gandhi. In the AAP, Arvind Kejriwal had been the uncontested leader since the foundation of the party in late 2012. He secured a sweeping victory in the December 2013 Delhi legislative assembly election, becoming the national capital territory's chief minister. He resigned as Chief Minister after 49 days in protest against the moves of other parties in the legislative assembly to block the introduction of an anti-corruption bill. Instead, Kejriwal focused on the general election campaign, promising that he would fight against corruption at the national level. Although these three parties and their respective leaders were considered for our analysis, the focus of the study was on the two main parties and their candidates, as the Lok Sabha elections essentially represented a duel between these two parties. We included the AAP due to its regional election success in Delhi a few months before the Lok Sabha elections and due to the media attention the AAP had received nationally before the start of the general elections campaign.

To analyze how these three parties portrayed their own leading candidate as well as the two respective opponents, we focused on campaign materials that targeted a nationwide audience. The sample included the three parties' press releases and newspaper ads in *the Times of India* and in *Hindustan* during April and May 2014. Campaign events in India tend to last long and vary across regions. The parties' press releases thus enabled us to capture the essence of the national campaign, as press releases published on the parties' national campaign websites typically had a national outlook.

Content analyses

The two attribute dimensions defined in the codebook are based on the categories established by McCombs et al. (2000). McCombs' analysis of candidate images in political news media coverage found that candidates are typically portrayed with regard to five substantive attribute categories. This study reproduced this categorization, but adapted the categories to the Indian context (Baumann, 2016). For example, relations between different religious communities and castes traditionally are a salient issue in Indian politics. The codebook therefore introduced a 'cultural' category to capture explicit statements about a candidate's stand on communalism and caste (see below). The five substantive candidate attributes were defined as:

(1) *Political ideology and issue positions:* statements about a candidate's political ideology and positions on public issues; statements expressing the position of a candidate on specific policy issues. Notions such as leftist, rightist, communist, socialist, supporting the poor, supporting the disadvantaged, supporting farmers, supporting foreign direct investment, pro-business, liberal/neoliberal were coded under this category.

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(2) *Culture*: India-specific political orientation of a candidate with regard to secularism/communalism, inter-religious relationships, and caste. Attributes such as communalist, secular, Hindu-nationalist, pro upper caste, pro-Dalit, pro-Muslim, sectarian were coded under the 'culture' category.
(3) *Qualifications and experience:* statements about the competency and ability of a candidate for office; statements about his performance in previous political postings, his political skills, and biographical details/background of a candidate.
(4) *Personality and image*: statements about personal traits and features of the character of a candidate, including assertions about a candidate's charisma, natural intelligence, courage, ambition, independence, leadership quality, popularity and so on.
(5) *Integrity:* includes all explicit statements that a candidate is 'corrupt' or 'not corrupt' and statements about a candidate's trustworthiness.

For a more detailed description of the categories, see Baumann (2016).

Additionally, each candidate assertion was coded with regard to its tonality or affective attribute dimension: positive, neutral or negative. In cases where candidate assertions did not have a clear positive or negative connotation, they were coded as neutral. Each entry in the code sheet included descriptive references to the type of campaign material or the newspaper article, the page number, the language, and the date on which it was published.[2]

The two coders were graduate students majoring in Media Governance at the Centre for Culture, Media and Governance at Jamia Millia Islamia in New Delhi. Both coders were native Hindi-speakers and proficient in English with experience in coding. Neither had any political affiliations. After two weeks of training, the two coders coded 35 news items and 15 party campaign press releases individually to generate the inter-coder reliability value of.93 (Cohen's *kappa*). The final sample size was 716 candidate statements in both newspapers, and 458 candidate assertions in the three parties' campaign messages (Baumann, 2016).

Granger's causality test

Research question two of this study tested which agenda influenced which. The study applied Granger causality tests in EViews – a statistical software used mainly in time-series analysis – to determine the directional correlations between party campaign and media outlets. Granger causality tests are frequently used in economics to test whether the trend in one variable precedes the trends in others. A number of studies have used Granger causality tests to determine causal correlations in agenda-setting studies (Becketti, 2011; Brosius & Kepplinger, 1990; Russell Neuman, Guggenheim, Mo Jang, & Bae, 2014; Zheng, 2017). Granger causality analysis provides more accurate results than cross-lagged analysis because it not only predicts the direction of the agenda-setting process but also calculates the time span needed to generate linkages among different agendas for a specific study (Russell Neuman et al., 2014). Based on Granger's (1969) notion, variable Y can 'Granger cause' variable X if a study can predict X better with the past values of Y than when it is excluded (Freeman, 1983; Granger, 1969).

Time span is important to determine the direction of the agenda-setting effect between two agendas. This study used Granger causality analysis to first determine the proper time lag for this study and then to explore agenda-setting effects between party campaigns and

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the press. The AIC value – a criterion commonly applied for lag selection in Granger causality tests (Becketti, 2013) – indicates that thirteen days is the best time lag for this study.

Results

First-level agenda-setting: the party campaigns and the newspapers' coverage pattern

To answer RQ1a, the frequencies of candidate statements in the party campaigns and newspaper coverage revealed a striking pattern. As shown in Figure 1, the BJP's Narendra Modi dominated both party and newspaper agendas, followed by Rahul Gandhi from the INC and Arvind Kejriwal from the AAP. More specifically (see Figure 2), in the party agendas, Modi received the most attention in all three parties' campaigns. Gandhi received equal attention from both BJP and INC, while Kejrwal received attention only from his own party, the AAP. The INC and the BJP practically ignored him in their campaigns. In the media agendas, it was again Modi who dominated the coverage of both the *Times of India* and *Hindustan*. *Hindustan* covered Gandhi more prominently than Kejriwal, while the *Times of India* gave equal attention to Kejrwal and Gandhi.

Second-level agenda-setting: substantive attributes

For research question 1b, the five substantive attribute dimensions were covered with consistency in the party campaigns and in newspaper coverage. Figure 3(a–c) shows that the two newspapers were quite consistent in their portrayal of the three candidates, but the parties adopted different strategies with regard to the substantive attributes of their own and the two opponent candidates.

More specifically, the INC in its campaign stressed its own candidate's (Gandhi) political ideology (A1), depicting him as a non-divisive candidate. The INC's aim behind this strategy was clearly to present Gandhi as a secular, non-divisive leader, in contrast to Modi, who allegedly represented a right-wing, hindu-nationalist political ideology,

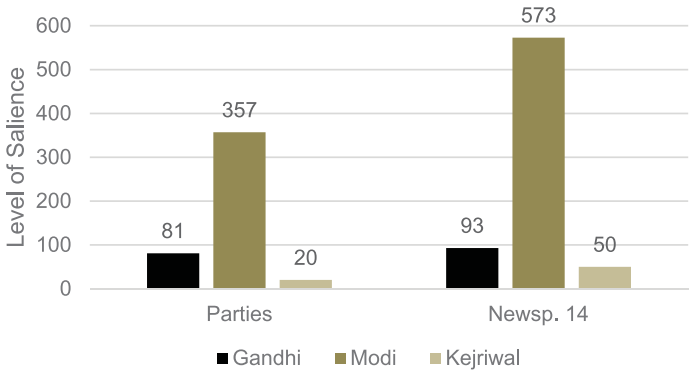

Figure 1. Candidate salience in party campaigns (INC, BJP and AAP) and in newspapers coverage (Times of India and Hindustan) during the 2014 Lok Sabha election campaign.

Note: N = number of candidate statements in six-week-period.

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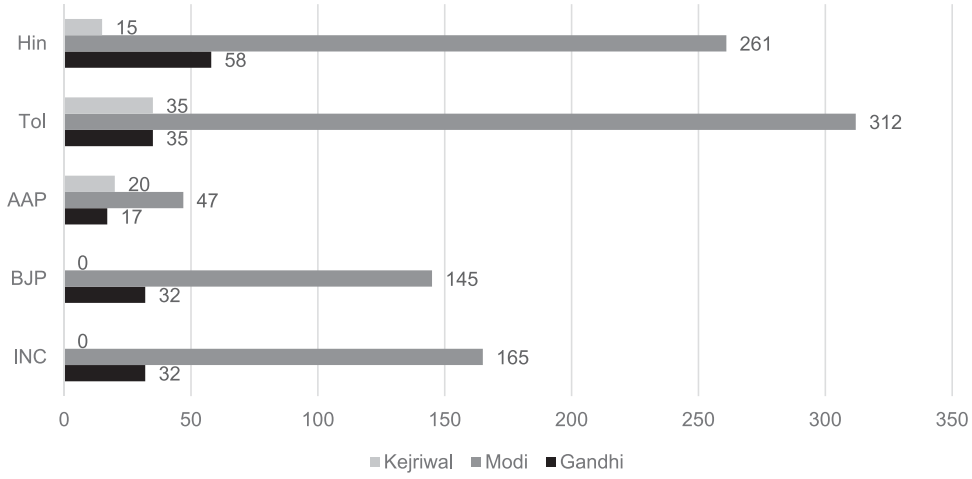

Figure 2. Candidate salience in party campaigns and in newspaper coverage (Times of India and Hindustan) during the 2014 Lok Sabha election campaign.

which according to the INC's was threatening India's inter-communal harmony. The BJP on the other hand focused on Gandhi's personality (A4) in its campaign. It painted the picture of the INC candidate as a weak political figure who owed his political status solely to his family name and who was only grudgingly accepting his designation as the future party leader. The AAP for its part mainly depicted Gandhi as a corrupt politician (A5) in its campaign. It did so partly because its success in the Delhi Regional Assembly the previous year was based on the party's aggressive anti-corruption rhetoric which had caused many Delhiites to vote for the new party. The two newspapers addressed similar agendas in their coverage of Rahul Gandhi, although *Hindustan* associated the INC leader more clearly with the personality and image (A4) and integrity (A5) attributes (see Figure 3(a)) compared with the *Times of India*.

An equally mixed picture emerged in the analysis of Narendra Modi's depiction in the party campaigns. The BJP stressed its own prime ministerial candidate's issue positions and political ideology (A1), portraying him as a resolute reformer and as a guarantor for economic growth. The party also emphasized Modi's personality (A4), focusing on his charisma and his leadership qualities. The INC and the AAP, on the other hand, portrayed Modi primarily as a corrupt politician (A5). The integrity/corruption attribute (A5) also dominated *Hindustan*'s depiction of Modi, followed by statements about his personality (A4). The *Times of India* mainly stressed Modi's personality attributes (A4) and his image as a non-secular, hindu-nationalist figure (A2) (in Figure 3(b)).

Finally, Arvind Kejriwal, whose Aam Aadmi Party had significantly less resources for the Lok Sabha campaign than the two large national parties, was entirely ignored by both the BJP and the INC campaigns. His own party primarily depicted him through the personality and image attribute (A4) lens, addressing his success in the previous Delhi Regional Assembly election and his fight against the allegedly corrupt political establishment. This is also true for the two newspapers, who both highlighted Kejriwal's personality (A4) in their campaign coverage (in Figure 3(c)).

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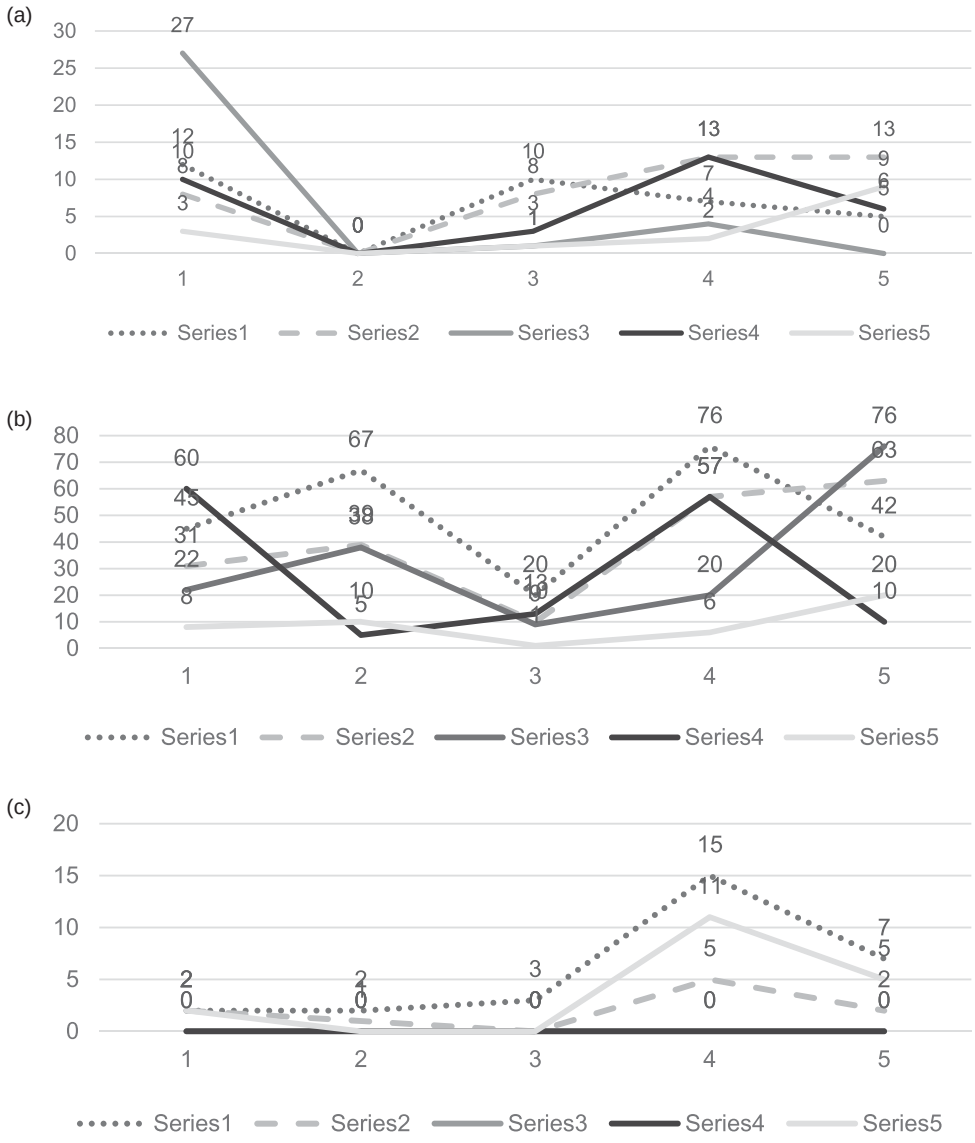

Figure 3. (a) Substantive candidate attribute salience for Gandhi (INC) during the 2014 Lok Sabha election campaign. **(b)** Substantive candidate attribute salience for Modi (BJP) during the 2014 Lok Sabha election campaign **(c)** Substantive candidate attribute salience for Kejriwal (AAP) during the 2014 Lok Sabha election campaign.

Note: a. A1 = Political ideology and issue positions; A2 = Culture; A3 = Qualifications and experience; A4 = Personality and image; A5 = Integrity. b. ToI = Times of India; Hin = Hindustan

Second-level agenda-setting: affective attributes

A more nuanced picture of the parties' campaign strategies evolves when focusing on affective candidate attributes (positive and negative tonality of statements about a candidate; RQ1c). Not surprisingly, negative statements about Modi and positive statements about Gandhi dominated the INC's campaign agenda while the opposite logic was prevalent in the BJP's agenda. 80% of all candidate statements in the BJP's campaign were

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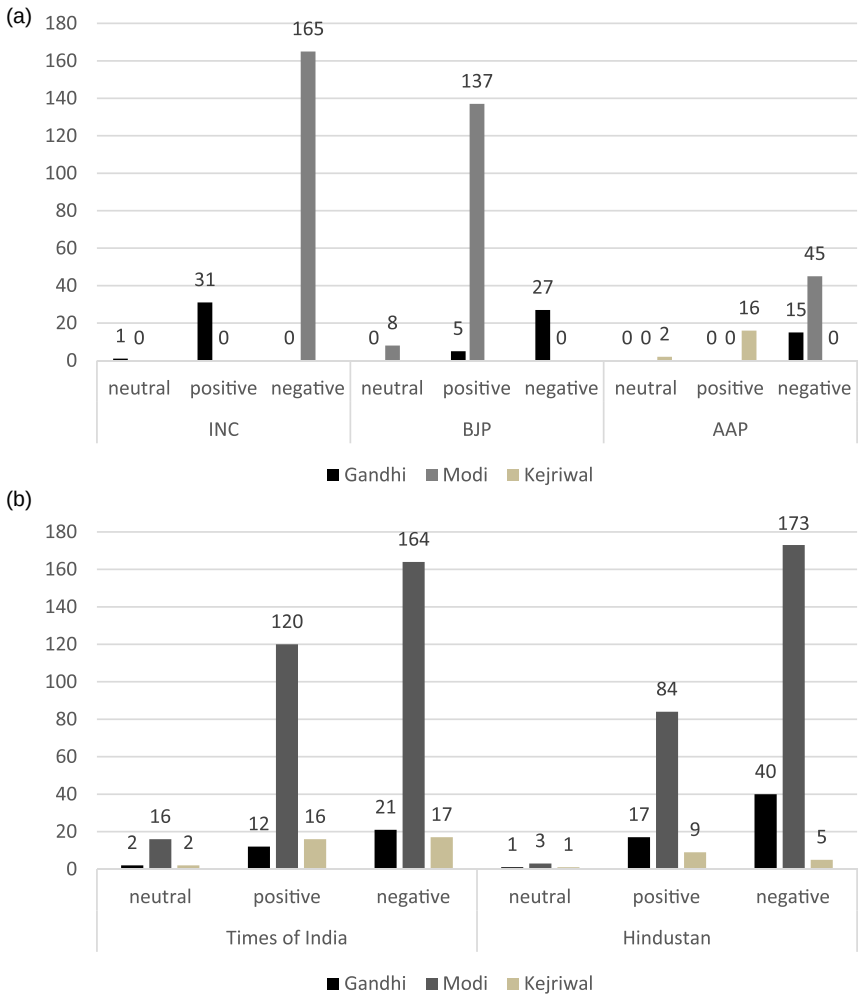

Figure 4. (a) Affective candidate attribute salience in party campaigns during the 2014 Lok Sabha election campaign **(b)** Affective candidate attribute salience in newspapers during the 2014 Lok Sabha election campaign.

positive Modi statements, while around 15% of all BJP candidate statements were attacks on Rahul Gandhi. The BJP hence followed a 'strategy of charm' in its campaign, strongly focusing on its own candidate, Narendra Modi. The INC pursued a different strategy: over 80% of its candidate statements were attacks against Modi, while less than 20% pertained to the party's own candidate Gandhi. All Gandhi statements in the INC campaign had, of course, a positive tone. Both the INC and the BJP ignored the AAP candidate in their campaigns, while Kejriwal's party portrayed its own leader in a positive light, while attacking the other two parties' candidates (negative statements; see Figure 4(a)).

Statements about Modi also dominated the newspaper agendas. Interestingly, negative Modi statements were about 1.5 times more salient than positive ones in both newspapers. In the *Times of India*, about 80% of the overall positive candidate statements referred to Modi, 8% to Gandhi and 10% to Kejrwal. At the same time, roughly 80% of the paper's

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negative candidate statements also targeted Modi, while 10% referred to Gandhi and 8% to Kejrwal. In *Hindustan's* campaign coverage, Modi accounted for 76% of all positive candidate statements, Gandhi for 15% and Kejwal for 8%. Modi also clearly dominated *Hindustan*'s negative candidate portrayal. Negative assertions about Modi made up 80% of all of *Hindustan*'s negative candidate statements, while Gandhi accounted for18% and Kejriwal for 2% of *Hindustan*'s negative candidate assertions.

Partly significant reciprocal agenda-setting effects

Correlations and Granger's causality tests were conducted to identify possible causal agenda-setting effects between the party campaigns and the two newspapers. H1 stated that the salience of candidates in the party campaigns correlated with the salience of candidates in the newspapers. Pearson's correlation showed a significant correlation ($r = .84$, $p < .001$). Therefore, H1 was supported. H2 assumed that the salience of substantive candidate attributes in the party campaigns correlated with the salience of these attributes in the newspapers. Pearson's correlation showed a significant correlation ($r = .90$, $p < .001$). H2 was thus also supported. H3 implied a correlation between the salience of affective candidate attributes in the party campaigns and in the newspapers. In support of H3, Pearson's correlation indicated a significant correlation ($r = .99$, $p < .001$).

To answer RQ2, the Granger's causality tests revealed a pattern that is less straightforward. As shown in Table 1, the agenda-setting influence was essentially bi-directional with only a few significant Granger's causality values. In other words, the flow of arguments and the direction of causality between the party campaign and newspaper agendas were complex and nuanced. At the first level of agenda-setting (candidate salience), the relationship between party campaign agendas and newspaper agendas was bi-directional. Even though the newspapers exerted a slightly stronger influence on the party campaigns with regard to the portrayal of Gandhi and Modi, and although party campaigns had a slightly stronger influence on the press with regard to the portrayal of Kejriwal, we discovered no significant Granger's causality effects. The picture is similarly mixed at the second level of agenda-setting (candidate attribute salience). For *substantive candidate attributes*, agenda-setting effects between party campaigns and newspaper coverage were also reciprocal, except for the attribute of integrity and corruption (A5), where Granger's causality test suggests a stronger influence of newspaper coverage on the party campaigns than vice versa ($F = 22.90$, $p < .05$). For *affective candidate attribute salience,* again, agenda-setting effects were limited and reciprocal. The party campaigns exerted a slightly stronger influence over the newspaper agenda than vice versa, but the Granger's causality tests didn't show significant causal effects. The results indicated that although party campaigns exerted some limited influence on the newspapers' agenda, the two newspapers' campaign coverage was primarily defined by their own logic. This is good news for the independence of India's press from political influence, at least with regard to two of the country's most influential national newspapers (Baumann, 2016).

Discussion and conclusion

With over 800 million Indians eligible to vote, the 2014 Indian general elections were the largest democratic exercise the world has ever witnessed. Our study shows that despite the

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Table 1. Granger causality results for party campaigns and newspaper coverage.

Category		F statistics	Prob.	AIC
Direction of causality: from party to media				
Candidates	Gandhi	1.91	.25	9.01
	Modi	1.82	.41	9.93
	Kejriwal	0.90	.64	1.44
Substantive Attributes (A1-A5)	Political ideology	0.15	.99	8.33
	Culture	3.63	.24	5.31
	Qualifications and experience	0.42	.87	5.00
	Personality and image	1.37	.50	6.35
	Integrity and corruption	0.36	.90	5.49
Affective Attributes	Positive about Gandhi	1.83	.41	4.03
	Negative about Gandhi	0.22	.97	5.67
	Positive about Modi	0.89	.65	8.53
	Negative about Modi	3.88	.22	9.79
	Positive about Gandhi – Negative about Modi	203.48	.005**	7.93
	Negative about Modi – Positive about Gandhi	7.08	.13^{+}	6.56
Direction of causality: from media to party				
Candidates	Gandhi	0.84	.40	9.01
	Modi	0.64	.76	9.93
	Kejriwal	3.47	.25	1.44
Substantive Attributes (A1-A5)	Political ideology	0.39	.88	8.33
	Culture	1.01	.60	5.31
	Qualifications and experience	1.04	.59	5.00
	Personality and image	0.60	.77	6.35
	Integrity and corruption	22.90	.04*	5.49
Affective Attributes	Positive about Gandhi	0.94	.63	4.03
	Negative about Gandhi	0.87	.65	5.67
	Positive about Modi	0.94	.63	8.53
	Negative about Modi	0.24	.96	9.79
	Positive about Gandhi – Negative about Modi	0.41	.87	7.93
	Negative about Modi – Positive about Modi	0.35	.91	6.56

*$p < .05$; **$p < .01$. $^{+}p = .13$.

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dimension and the complexity of Indian democracy, agenda-setting processes that have been witnessed in the West also occur in India. However, the correlation between party campaigns and newspaper coverage turned out to be partly significant and largely bi-directional at both levels of agenda-setting. Granger's causality test further showed more insignificant than significant relationships. It indicated that although media and party agendas are closely correlated, parties seldom succeed in directly setting the agendas of large and economically successful newspapers.

It's all about Modi

In retrospect, the party campaign-newspaper relation can be explained by the political trends in India that had already emerged before the start of the 2014 election campaign. The characteristics of Indian politics in the months before the Lok Sabha campaign have set in motion a cycle of self-reinforcing and bi-directional agenda-setting effects. The dynamics at play were based on two broad developments in Indian politics (Baumann, 2016):

(1) The decline of the incumbent Congress Party: the secular INC had dominated Indian politics for most of the nearly seven decades since independence from Britain. Especially during the last Congress-led administration that began in 2009, the party became incapable of delivering governance and was increasingly perceived as corrupt, aloof and uninspired. Corruption scandals that involved high party officials and even cabinet members had dominated the headlines throughout Manmohan Singh's second term as Prime Minister. The dynastic organization of the party, which has been ruled by the Nehru-Gandhi family since the 1920s, had become increasingly scrutinized. Italian-born Congress president Sonia Gandhi unofficially designated her son to lead the party in the 2014 elections as a representative of the 5th generation of the family. Rahul's apparent reluctance to take on political responsibility and his seeming incompetence and awkwardness in political matters were one of the main underlying factors that led to the Congress Party's humiliating performance in the Lok Sabha elections.

(2) The rise of Narendra Modi: the charismatic chief minister of Gujarat had gained national popularity long before he was nominated as the BJP's candidate for Prime Minister. Modi cleverly marketed the economic development of Gujarat as his personal achievement, implying that his ability to deliver governance could bring the whole country forward. By stressing the success of his 'Gujarat model', Modi also tried to take public attention away from accusations of his role as Chief Minister during the Gujarat riots of 2002, where over 1000 people, mostly Muslims, had lost their life. Modi was seen as a threat to the secular foundations of the state by intellectuals and India's large Muslim minority. His Hindu nationalistic ideology, rhetoric brilliance, modest background and leadership qualities made him a savior in the eyes of many Indians and especially among right wing Hindu nationalists. It is for these reasons that Modi gained enormous media attention even long before he officially entered the stage of national politics. The BJP exploited Modi's attention advantage in the media by making the BJP campaign essentially a 'Modi campaign'. The BJP's credo even before launching its official campaign seemed clear: 'supporting the BJP = supporting Modi.'

Overall, the parties were faced with the following situation:

The BJP had to try to counter accusations of Modi as a divisive figure that would spread communal hatred and threaten the secular foundation of the Indian polity. The party stressed Modi's strong leadership qualities and promised that he would deliver governance and economic development for all of India. The BJP seemed very confident vis-à-vis the Congress Party and its main candidate Gandhi. Due to Gandhi's veritable neglect by the media before the start of the elections and his perceived weakness and reluctance, the BJP campaign could afford to ignore Modi's main rival and instead focus on creating a positive image of its own candidate. Modi's BJP followed a 'charm strategy' of self-promotion, largely abstaining from attack ads against opponent candidates.

For the Congress Party, the opposite logic was at play. The party knew how poorly Gandhi performed in interviews and public appearances and tried to take as much attention away from its own candidate, who was already widely ignored by the press. Aware of the massive media attention Modi received, the Congress pursued an offensive attack

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strategy in its campaign, almost entirely focusing on creating a negative image of its main opponent, Narendra Modi.

The AAP lacked the resources to run a nationwide campaign like the INC and the BJP. It therefore concentrated on constituencies where it thought it had a chance of winning. As the AAP's most serious rivals were often BJP candidates, the party focused its campaign on heavy attacks against Modi, especially in the second half of the elections when the overwhelming BJP victory became tangible.

The logic behind election news coverage

The focus on Modi in the party campaigns further reinforced his dominant status in the newspapers' election coverage. Results indicated either some sympathies between *Hindustan* journalists and the INC, skepticism towards the BJP and its leading candidate, or a mixture of both. The English language *Times of India*, which has a reputation of being non-partisan and of reporting independently, was not substantially influenced by party campaigns. Overall, the party campaigns did not succeed in substantially shaping the newspaper agendas. Our results showed no indications that national high-status newspapers in India, at least the *Times of India* and *Hindustan*, are prone to political influence in their election campaign coverage. Nonetheless, the high degree of correspondence between newspaper and party campaign agendas at both levels of agenda-setting suggests that the newspapers couldn't ignore to cover the stories that emerged during the Lok Sabha campaign, some of which were the result of party campaign efforts.

Although existing studies on the party campaigns – media nexus suggest an 'incumbency bonus' where the incumbent party receives more media attention, our study suggests that this logic is not at play if the incumbent party or coalition is expected to face a clear defeat in an upcoming election. In the context of India, some existing studies found evidence for the historical bonds between some media outlets and parties (e.g. Butler, Lahiri, & Roy, 1995). However, the rise of populist politics in India (Mazzoleni, Stewart, & Horsfield, 2003) and media commercialization may have a mitigating effect on the influence political parties exert over the media. Moreover, the highly respected Election Commission of India, the autonomous constitutional authority responsible for administering election processes, also monitors parties' behavior to prevent exaggerated political influence of the media's coverage. Our research of the agenda-setting effects between political campaigns and the media in India supports previous studies that suggest the news media's ambition to function as a balanced 'fourth estate', at least at the level of the largest national newspapers (Baumann, 2016; de Swert & Walgrave, 2006).

Our data and the nature of the Indian political and media systems suggest that India offers excellent conditions for more sophisticated agenda-setting studies. Future studies should focus on the vastly expanding regional vernacular press (Neyazi, Chakraborty, & Chandra, 2015) to explore regional differences and shed light on possible political pressure on the media at state, regional and local levels of Indian politics. This study is limited to the national level of Indian politics and two of the country's most influential and most successful national newspapers. Given India's cultural and linguistic diversity with over 100 languages (Sonwalkar, 2002), and the country's multi-level media system (Baumann, 2016; Neyazi, 2014; Shahin et al., 2016), examining regional and local campaigns would reveal

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more nuanced dynamics between party campaigns and political news coverage, as well as intermedia agenda-setting between national and local media outlets. Further, future studies should pay more attention to the electronic media, which we were unable to do due to limited resources. With the rapidly expanding Indian television market and ever-higher internet penetration, India's media market is likely to become even more heterogeneous, dynamic and complex. The role of the media in the Indian democracy is likely to increase in importance, as rapidly growing budgets for political campaigns and ads at all levels of Indian politics indicate. We think it is pressing to analyze the mechanisms between political parties, the media and public opinion in more detail to acquire a more comprehensive understanding of the role of the media in Indian democracy. Our study serves as one step in this direction. In this sense, the absence of clear one-directional agenda-setting effects that this study revealed is good news for the functioning of an independent Indian press as a fourth estate (Baumann, 2016; Neyazi et al., 2015).

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Notes

1. According to the Indian Readership Survey 2014, *Hindustan* is India's second-largest daily newspaper with a readership of 14,746,000. Although *Dainik Jagran* has a larger readership (16,631,000), it has a strong focus on Northern India and the state of Uttar Pradesh in particular, whereas *Hindustan* has a more national outlook and is the most widely read Hindi-language paper in India's capital, New Delhi. *The Times of India* is the world's largest English-language daily newspaper and India's most influential English-language paper with a readership of 7,590,000 (Baumann, 2016).
2. The following assertions exemplify how candidate statements were coded (for the entire codebook, see Baumann, 2016).
   - *'The Congress accuses Modi of engaging in crony capitalism'* Coded as: Candidate: 2 (Narendra Modi); Substantive attribute: 5 (integrity (corruption); Affective attribute: 2 (negative).
   - *'A vote for the BJP is a vote for Modi. Voting for the BJP means voting for strong leadership'* Coded as: Candidate: 2 (Narendra Modi); Substantive attribute: 4 (personality and image); Affective attribute: 1 (positive).
   - *'Gandhi's vote bank in Uttar Pradesh is strong, as he would defend direct subsidies to farmers.'* Coded as: Candidate: 1 (Rahul Gandhi); Substantive attribute: 1 (political ideology and issue position); Affective attribute: 0 (neutral).
   - *'How will Kejriwal deliver on his promises? He is a tax collector; he has no experience as a politician at all.'* Coded as: Candidate: 3 (Arwind Kejriwal); Substantive attribute: 3 (qualifications and experience); Affective attribute: 2 (negative).
   - *'Modi is a divisive figure, he spreads communal hatred.'* Coded as: Candidate: 2 (Narendra Modi); Substantive attribute: 2 (culture); Affective attribute: 2 (negative).

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